

BARUCH

THE PROPHECY OF BARUCH.

PREFACE.

Baruch was a man of noble extraction, and learned in the law, secretary and disciple of the prophet Jeremias, and a sharer in his labours and persecutions; which is the reason why the ancient Fathers have considered this book as a part of the prophecy of Jeremias, and have usually quoted it under his name.

Ch. --- The frequent Heb. idioms shew it to have been originally in that language. Baruch wrote by inspiration of the Holy Ghost the letter comprising the five first chapters, which he carried to the Jews from their brethren at Babylon. The martyrologies place his death, Dec. 28. The sixth chapter contains a letter of Jeremias, to which allusion is clearly made 2 Mac. ii. 2. The Church still recites the works of Baruch under the name of Jeremias. Sab.

Pent. proph. 6. C. --- Many Fathers did so formerly, though they doubted not but Baruch was the author. See S. Iræn. v. 35. S. Aug. de Civ. Dei. xviii. 33. &c.

Others, with Origen (Prin. ii. 3.) specify the writer; and the Councils of Laodicea, Florence, and Trent, decide that it is canonical.

S. Jerom alleged it not against the Jews, as they denied its authority. W. --- See Jer. xxxii. 44. H.

--- In his preface on Jeremias he testifies that "it contains many things relating to Christ and the latter times." W. --- Grotius in vain attempts to represent some parts as interpolated (C. iii. 38.

&c. C.) and L. Cappellus has left some posthumous notes, which would represent the author as a stupid impostor, though he acknowledges his great learning. Houbigant.

BARUCH 1

CHAPTER I.

Ver. 1. Babylonia. Sept. "Babylon," where Jechonias was in prison, (H.) now the 5th year. v. 2.

Baruch accompanied his brother Saraïas. Jer. li. 59. C. --- Capel. supposes that the author confounded them together, which is not probable. Houb.

Ver. 2. Month, in which the king was taken. C. --- This was the fifth anniversary.

H. --- Fire: but soon extinguished. Usher --- The taking of the city was effected at intervals, (H.) during eleven years, in the fifth of which this book was written. Jerusalem was at last reduced to ashes.

As yet there were priests, a temple, &c. v. 7, 14. W. C.

Ver. 3. Jechonias. He was in prison, where the Jews met to hear the words of Jeremias; (li. 59.

&c. C.) or the king might hear the letter in private. Houbig.

Ver. 4. Sodi. Heb. zud, (H.) means "pride," and probably denotes the great river Euphrates. C.

--- Bochart reads Sur, (Houb.) or Sori. The city Sura was there. C.

Ver. 7. Joakim, or Eliacim, high priest under Manasses, &c. Is. xxii. 20. C. ---

The text only says that he was priest, and Capellus asserts there was no pontiff then. Houbigant.

Ver. 8. Siven; a Syriac month, corresponding with our May. M. --- Vessels; or,

"the vessels were of silver." H. --- By retrenching a, which, it would seem that they asked for the golden vessels.

Sedecias had made silver ones to supply their place. These also might have been taken away. C.

--- Baltassar had still those of gold, (Dan. v. 2. M.) or at least some of them. H.

--- Sedecias, now in favour, only asked for what he had made while a private man. Houbig.

Ver. 9. All. Cunctos should be vinclos, according to the Gr. "prisoners." C.

Ver. 10. Meat. Lit. "manna," as Sept. express Heb. monée; (H.) or as it is pointed, mincha; which properly means an "oblation" (Jer. xvii. 26. M.) of bread, wine, &c. C. --- And offerings.

Lit. "offer." --- Gr. "has for sin before frankincense. H.

Ver. 11. King. Gratitude and duty prompted them. Jer. xxix. 7. and 1 Tim. ii. 2. ---

Baltassar.

Evilmerodac, his elder brother, was in disgrace. Lyran. Jer. lii. 31. C. --- Heaven, as long and prosperous as possible. H. --- It was a customary salutation to say, O king, live for ever. Dan. ii.

4. Ps. lxxxviii. 30. C. --- Cappel. says Baltassar was not yet born. But how does he know this?

It might be the title of the heir apparent, (H.) or of the king's sons. We need not decide in a point of such antiquity. Houbig.

Ver. 12. Eyes, putting an end to our captivity, (Badwell) or causing us to detest our sins. C. ---

Days. This they knew was God's decree, and they submit. H. --- They prefer serving the Chaldees before other foreign nations. W.

Ver. 14. Proper festival days. C. --- Heb. mohed, or muád. They were still observed (H.) in the temple.

Ver. 20. Curses against transgressors. Lev. xxvi. Dan. ix. 11. C. --- Day. We feel the effects of sin. The land of Juda was not flourishing, though not yet laid waste. H.

Ver. 22. Serve, or sacrifice unto: (Sanct.) operata Deo: (Tibul.) or to worship. C.

ii. 21. C.

BARUCH 2

CHAPTER II.

Ver. 2. Heaven. After the death of Josias, the nation was exposed to the greatest misery. Its kings were imprisoned by the Egyptians, and then by the Chaldees; and surprising changes took place, all during the space of eight or nine years.

Ver. 3. Daughter. This is not mentioned in sacred history to have happened when this was written, (C.) except in the siege of Samaria. Some of the captives of Israel might be now at Babylon, as the places to which they had been sent were under the same king; and they confess their common transgressions and chastisements. All distinction of the kingdoms was now at an end. Some might also have been reduced to this extremity, when Joakim or Jechonias were besieged and taken. H. -- We should not know that a similar distress prevailed under Sedecias, if it had not been specified Lam. ii. 20. and iv. 10. This prayer greatly resembles that of Dan. ix. 4.

Ver. 4. Kings of Egypt and Babylon, while the Ammonites, &c. derided us.

Ver. 5. Under; a proverbial expression. Deut. xxviii. 13.

Ver. 9. Watched, to punish. When he spares, he seems to slumber. Jer. xlv. 27.

C.

Ver. 12. Justices. So God's law is frequently called, (Ps. cxviii.) because its observance makes us just. W.

Ver. 16. House: the temple, or from heaven. C.

Ver. 17. Justice, &c. they that are in hell shall not give justice to God: that is, they shall not acknowledge and glorify his justice, as penitent sinners do upon earth. Ch. --- And all in the grave are incapable of making known God's perfections. An appeal to his glory is thus often made. Is. xxxviii. 18. Ps. cxiii.

17. Eccli. vii. 24.

Ver. 18. Of evil is not in Greek. A soul which bears grandeur with pain, like Esther, and humbles itself before God, is most graciously received. H. --- Fail, by fasting. Such are the dispositions required for prayer. Ps. lxviii. 3.

Ver. 19. Fathers. Gr. adds, "and kings." --- Prayers. Gr. "mercy." We boast not of our good works. H. --- Mercy may denote prayer or humiliation. Theodoret gives a better sense: (C.) "We trust not in the just works of our fathers, or of ourselves, to receive any pity." H.

Ver. 21. Serve, as Jeremias (xxv. 9. and xxvii. 7. and xxviii. 14.) repeatedly admonished.

Ver. 23. Footstep. It shall become a desert. Isa. xxxiii. 8. Lam. i. 4.

Ver. 24. Place. The soldiers ransacked the tombs in hopes of plunder. Joakim was left unburied.

This would be very affliction to the Jews. Jer. viii. 1. and xxii. 19. and xxxvi. 30.

C.

Ver. 25. Banishment. Syr. "captivity;" (Theod.) or "by pestilence inflicted by God:" apostole.

Grot. Jer. xxxii. 36.

Ver. 26. Day. Its vessels were taken away, (C. i. 8.) and few were left to attend.

C. --- Grotius answers this difficulty. Houbig. --- The prophet foresees the event. W.

Ver. 30. Heart, and be seriously converted, (H.) as the prophets had foretold.

Osee ii. 7. &c.

Ver. 33. Neck. Lit. "back," insensible of stripes. C.

Ver. 34. Thereof. Lit. "of them;" eis. But ei is more (H.) conformable to the Greek. C.

Ver. 35. Another. Gr. "an everlasting covenant," (H.) by Christ, (Maldon.) prefigured by that which Nehemias renewed. 2 Esd. ix. 38. C. --- The law of Moses was in force till Christ came.

His law continues unto the end. W.

BARUCH 3

CHAPTER III.

Ver. 3. Everlastingly. is such a short-lived creature an object worthy of thy eternal wrath? Job xiii. 25. and xiv. 1. Ps. cii. 13.

Ver. 4. Dead; banished, (v. 11. Ezech. xxxvii. 5.) or of the ancient patriarchs. This motive is frequently urged.

Ex. xxxii. 13. Lev. xxvi. 41. Deut. ix. 27. Dan. iii. 35. Jer. xv. 1. C. --- People in sin and misery seem dead, (v. 11.) yet may revive by grace. W.

Ver. 5. Hand. Save us by thy power, and for thy own name's sake. Jos. vii. 9.

Ver. 8. Offence. Gr. "debt." Parents might sell their children. Mat. xviii. 25. God threatens his rebellious people, that they shall be forced to borrow. Deut.

xxviii. 44. C.

Ver. 9. Hear. God replies. H. --- The Church has long read this has holy scripture, on the eves of Easter and Pentecost. W. --- This second part contains an instruction respecting true wisdom; which is to be found in God alone, (C.) in in the people to whom he is pleased to communicate it.

H.

Ver. 11. Grown. Houbigant, "growing." Five years had not elapsed: (Cappel.) yet they knew their captivity would be long. --- Dead. Some might yield to idolatry. Dan. iii. 7. 12. H. --- They were in a manner buried, (Ps. lxxxvii. 5.) and forced to dwell among people where they were exposed to many defilements, as if they had been near a dead body. Lev. xi. 25.

Ver. 13. Peace. There is none for the wicked; but only for the observers of the law. --- For ever.

Many read, "upon the land," conformably to the Greek.

Ver. 15. Treasures? How few are truly wise and virtuous! The great men of the world have missed their aim. Israel has received the law. Yet where is the fruit of it? This is developed in the sequel.

Ver. 16. Nations of Assyria? &c. They esteemed themselves as lords of nature, and delighted in hunting. The beasts and birds are subject to them. Gen. i. 26.

Jer. xxvii. 6. Dan. ii. 38. C.

Ver. 18. Unsearchable? Shall they not find the fruit of their works? W.

Ver. 20. Men; heirs of those conquerors, and equally in the dark. C.

Ver. 22. Theman, the capital city of Edom. Ch. --- Eliphaz was king. Jer. xlix. 7.

--- The Phœnicians, so famous for industry, had no idea of true wisdom, no more then the Ismaelites, &c.

C.

Ver. 23. Agar, the mother of the Ismaelites. Ch. --- Merrha, probably in Arabia.

--- Fables. This may be a reproach, or a commendation. Those nations delighted in enigmatical and sententious discourses. 3 K. x. 1. C. --- Instructors of mankind deserve praise, not those who devise false gods for lucre. S. Aug.

de Civ. Dei. vi. 5. &c. W.

Ver. 24. Possession. All the world belongs to him: yet how few partake of his wisdom!

Ver. 26. Giants, before and after the deluge. Gen. vi. Noe and Israel were preferred before them.

Ver. 29. Clouds? No human industry can procure this blessing. God alone is the dispenser of it.

Deut. xxx. 12. C. --- His grace makes the discovery easy. Mat. xi. 30. W.

Ver. 32. Evermore. Lit. "in the eternal time," or so long ago; (H.) designed to continue, while kingdoms shall change. Eccle. i. 4.

Ver. 33. Trembling. The sun stops, goes back, or withdraws its light, at his command. Jos. x. 12.

and 4 K. xx. 9. Mat. xxvii. 45. Job xxxvi. 30.

Ver. 34. Watches. They are like his soldiers. Judg. v. 20. Eccli. xliii. 12. C.

Ver. 38. Earth, &c. by the mystery of the incarnation, by means of which the son of God came visibly amongst us, and conversed with men. The prophets often speak of things to come as if they were past, to express the certainty of the event of the things foretold. Ch. C. --- Most of the Fathers prove Christ's divinity from this text. W. See Tert. c. Prax. 6. S. Cyp. c. Jud. ii. 5. Eus.

Dem. vi. 19. --- If we explain it of wisdom, it comes to the same purpose, as Christ is the wisdom of God. 1 Cor. i. 30. Compare Prov. viii. 30. Eccli. xxiv. 12.

Wisd. ix. 10. which no one ever suspected to be interpolated. C. Pref.

BARUCH 4

CHAPTER IV.

Ver. 1. Ever. True wisdom may be found in the law. It constitutes the happiness of Israel. Deut.

iv. 7. Christ perfected and fulfilled it. Mat. v. 7. --- Life. Moses promised temporal blessings; (C. iii. 14. Deut. xxx. 15.) yet the faithful would be rewarded eternally. C. --- Wisdom is the law of God. C. iii. 12. W.

Ver. 3. Nation. Be faithful, lest another take thy place. This Christians have done. Deut. xxxii.

21. C.

Ver. 5. Memorial. Gr. lit. "O memorable Israel." H. --- Ye are left to support and restore the nation. This part of the letter is for their comfort.

Ver. 6. Sold, like slaves, or people taken in war. C.

Ver. 8. God. Lit. "Him." Gr. "the Eternal." H. --- This is taken from Deut. xxxii. 15.

C. ---

Nursed you. The city is beautifully personified as a widow. v. 12. H.

Ver. 9. Near. Hebrew would be "daughters of Sion." v. 14.

Ver. 15. Tongue. So the Chaldees are described, Deut. xxviii. 49. Is. xxxiii. 19. C.

Ver. 16. Children. Gr. "daughters." H. --- Many of both sexes were taken with Jechonias. C. ---

Jerusalem comforts her children, and assures them of God's mercy. W.

Ver. 20. Peace: the ornaments worn in my prosperity. --- Sackcloth, or a rough garment, used by penitents and in times of public distress.

Ver. 25. Neck. Mardochai, Daniel, &c. were governors. Is. xl. 14. These predictions were more fully verified when the Gentiles embraced the gospel. C.

Ver. 28. When. Gr. "now ten times as much, being converted, seek him." H. ---

The Jews became much more docile and attached to the law.

Ver. 30. Named thee as his servant, spouse, (C.) and intimate friend.

Ver. 31. The. Gr. Deilaioi. "wretched those who have injured thee, and rejoiced in thy fall!

Wretched the cities," &c. H.

Ver. 32. She; Babylon. Ch. --- Gr. "Wretched she," &c. H. --- Babylon shall fall a prey to Cyrus.

Ver. 35. Fire of war. --- Devils. Whether they really dwell in ruins, or the people were of that opinion, (as the common sort are still) is not clear. Jer. l. 39. Is.

xxxiv. 14.

Ver. 37. East and west. From Babylon and from the islands. Is. xi. 11. Zac. viii.

7.

BARUCH 5

CHAPTER V.

Ver. 2. Garment. Heb. "cloak," (Sanct.) such as were worn by people under no disgrace. C. iv.

20. Tamar had one very costly. 2 K. xiii. 18. C. --- Justice, or mercy. God is bound to fulfill his gracious promises. W.

Ver. 3. His. Gr. "thy." Christ, the sun of justice, would effect this. Is. lx. 1.

Ver. 4. Piety. Thus shall Jerusalem be distinguished after the captivity; but still more so when Christ shall appear, and give peace to his Church, after the ages of persecution.

Ver. 5. Arise. C. iv. 36. Is. lii. 2. --- God. They remember his law with pleasure.

Ver. 6. Children. Gr. "the throne." The return of the captives was a triumph. Is.

xlvi. 20. and xlix. 22. They had abundance of horses, &c. 1 Esd. ii. 66. Darius gave them a convoy of 1000

horsemen. 3 Esd. v. 2. Jos. Ant. xi. 4.

Ver. 7. Diligently, without stumbling under the pillar of God's protection. Is. xl.

3. C.

Ad vos quâ veniet, tumidi subsidite montes

Et faciles curvis vallibus este viæ. Ovid. Am. ii. 16.

Ver. 8. Woods. This is a poetical description. They shall pass through the sands of Arabia, as if they were under a delightful shade.

BARUCH 6

CHAPTER VI.

A copy. Sept. place this after the Lamentations, which follow Baruch. H. ---

Jeremias wrote it before the captives departed. Baruch read it to them at Babylon, and it was sent back to Jerusalem. W. --- It might be delivered to the captives at Reblatha. We have it not entire, as another circumstance respecting the ark is mentioned. 2 Mac. ii. 5. C.

Ver. 2. Seven generations; that is, seventy years. Ch. --- A generation sometimes consisted of seven, ten, fifteen, thirty, thirty-five, fifty, or a hundred years. A. Lap. Menage. --- Eighteen years of the seventy had already elapsed.

C. --- Seven is often put for many, (H.) or a general number, (W.) because so many days form a week. H. --- Grotius substitutes dekadon

for geneon,

"seven decads," very properly. Houbigant.

Ver. 3. Shoulders. This custom was very ancient, suggested by the avarice of the priests, who begged on such occasions. Menander, ap. Clem. protrep.

Ver. 4. Fear. Worship not such things. H.

Ver. 6. Angel Michael, the conductor of Israel in the desert, &c. Dan. x. 13. Ex.

xxxiii. 2. C. ---

He protected them also in Babylon. W.

Ver. 8. Gay. Nothing could be more despicable. C.

Ver. 10. The Harlots. Their hire was rejected by the Lord. But idols suffered themselves to be despoiled or adorned at pleasure. Gr. "But they will give of them even to harlots under the same roof, while they adorn them (idols) like men with garments, gods of gold, silver, and wood." H.

Ver. 12. Them, of account of the many votaries, v. 16. Arnobius (6) ridicules such gods. C. ---

Prot. adopt similar arguments against the real presence as if we believed that Christ was hurt when the sacramental species were broken or devoured by vermin. A little more boldness will prompt them to reject the divinity of Christ, who was pleased to give up his body to those who treated him shamefully.

Almost every argument which is levelled against Christ's real presence in the blessed Eucharist, maybe turned against the incarnation; and hence so many now become Socinians, being unwilling to submit their understanding to the mysteries of religion. To apply these texts to holy pictures, would be nugatory.

See Is. xl 18. H. --- The absurdities here specified, shew how foolish are those who serve idols or take any images to be gods. W. ---

Calvin represents the pagans as adoring God under the images, as if they used them in the same light as Catholics do; which is contrary to this epistle,

&c. T.

Ver. 13. Judge, or ruler. C. --- The sceptre and spear were badges of power.

Eustath. --- Mars had a sword, Hercules a club. We know little of the idols of Babylon.

Ver. 15. Vessel; armour, or any utensil. C.

Ver. 18. Candles. Lit. "lamps." H. --- Some temples in Egypt were famous for their number.

Herod. ii. 62. --- The Lord prescribed them to be used. But who ever imagined that they stood in need of them to see, as the idolaters supposed their idols did?

Ver. 19. Hearts: the wood is worm-eaten. C.

Ver. 24. Price, foolishly believing that they have divine power. W.

Ver. 26. Gifts. The Chaldees supposed that Bel could eat. Dan. xiv. --- Dead.

Food was placed on the tombs. S. Aug. abolished this custom in Africa.

Ver. 27. Take. Gr. "salt." They give none to the poor, for fear of their imposture being detected, though they allow even the unclean to eat. v. 28. Lev. xii. 2.

Deut. xiv. 29.

Ver. 29. Women. They make gods. C. --- Qui rogat, ille facit. Mart. viii. 24.

Ver. 30. Shaven, as in mourning, contrary to the custom of Israel. Lev. xxi. 10.

C. --- Heads.

The Jewish priests wore mitres or caps.

Ver. 31. Dead, even of Adonis, (H.) whose worship is here ridiculed. C. - -- At Biblos people bewailed his death, and the next day proclaimed that he was alive. All cut off their hair, as the Egyptians do for Apis, except such as submitted to prostitute themselves to strangers. The hire they consecrated to Venus. Lucian, Dea Syra. --- At funerals a feast was usually made, as is still the custom in Syria, (Roger. ii. 14.) and near Bagdad. Chardin. ii. 7.

Ver. 34. Requite. Gr. "brass," much less gold. H.

Ver. 40. Chaldees. The priests themselves despise the idols most, (C.) and expose them to contempt, by pretending that they work miracles. H. --- "Those who first set up representations of the gods, deprived cities of reverential awe, and increased the error," said Varro; "prudently supposing that gods might easily be contemned, when like stupid images." In simulacrorum stoliditate. S.

Aug. de Civ. Dei. iv. 26.

Ver. 41. They. Gr. "he could perceive. And they reflecting on this, cannot still abandon them; for they have no sense." H. --- They are so stupid, that they will not quit such impotent idols. C.

Ver. 42. Women. Aristophanes calls harlots, "corded bodies." Eccles. Act. i.

The women of Babylon "prostituted themselves once, in honour of Venus, (H.

Mylitta. C.) sitting with crowns on their heads in the temple, till some stranger selected them, and took them from their partition, made with cords," (H.) to some more secret place, where they broke their bands. Herod. i. 199.

C. --- That some deluded women, led by various desires, should think thus to honour that impure deity, by an action which some modern casuists have not scrupled to rank among simple venial sins, cannot excite our astonishment so much, when we reflect on the tenets of the ancient Gnostics, and of Antinomians at the present day, whom J. Wesley, the last founder of the Methodists, applauded and followed even in the meridian of the gospel light!

See Deut. xvi. 22.

and xxiii. 17. Yet these men read and perhaps distributed the Bible! --- Stones.

Lit. "bones;" (H.) or the refuse of what had been crushed, (pitura. Athen. ii. 14.) to excite impure love. M. T. ---

Theocritus (Phar.) represents a witch doing the like; and Sanchez tells us, that some were taken in the fact in Spain. C. --- Fumigation, used by the Babylonians after marriage, (Herod. i. 198.) may be insinuated. Grotius.

Ver. 45. To be. Is. xliv. 14. Horace (i. Sat. 8) introduces Priapus thus ridiculously explaining his origin; "I was formerly an useless piece of a fig-tree; when the workman, not knowing whether to make a bench or a Priapus, chose rather that I should be a god. Hence I am a god, the greatest terror of thieves and birds." Sept. "they are nothing but what the workmen wish to form." H.

Ver. 51. Them. Gr. has simply, (C.) "Who then knows not that they are no gods?" H.

Ver. 53. Daws. They have no greater influence (C.) than jackdaws.

Ver. 58. Gods. Sept. repeat this after satisfied, or "will use;" and here add, "or a pillar of wood in palaces, than," &c. H.

Ver. 59. Obedient to God. They were appointed to mark out the seasons, &c.

(Gen. i. 14.) and if any creature were worthy of adoration, they would. C. --- The Babylonians adored them as well as statues, and therefore their proper destination is specified here and by Moses.

Ver. 69. Scarecrow. Priapus answered this glorious purpose. v. 45. H. --- When birds become accustomed to such things, they mind them not. C.

Ver. 71. Scarlet. Gr. "marble" coloured wood. Grotius would substitute margarou, "a pearl,"

which decays through age. C. --- Gr. also, "From the purple, which also shines upon them rotting, you shall," &c. Marmarou means, "of marble or shining."

Ver. 72. Reproach, provided he also avoid the idols of the mind and of the heart. H.